

Musical textures

Texture is a vital part of musical composition. A solo is the simplest texture, but extra parts—similar or contrasting—can be added to include harmony and color to the finished work.

SEE ALSO

◀ 92–93 What is a tune?

◀ 118–119 Harmony

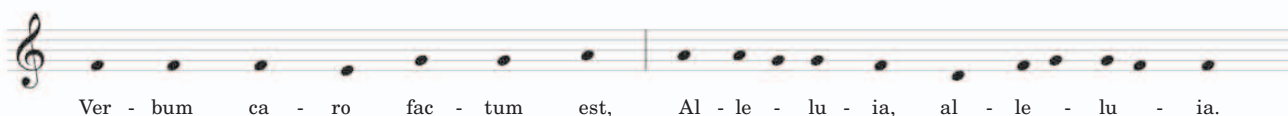
◀ 196–197 Words and music

Plainchant

Plainsong, or plainchant, is an ancient form of solo melody that has been used in church rituals for more than 1,000 years. Heard today in the singing of psalms, it is notated on a staff, but there is no indication of a rhythm or pulse.

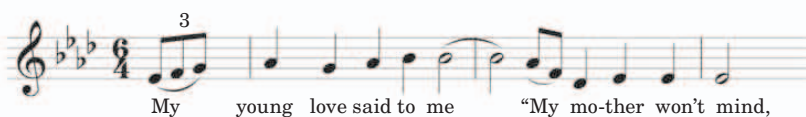
▽ Christmas chant

This plainchant is a setting of a joyful Christmas text and uses only five different tones, the first five notes of the Dorian mode.



Solo melody

A solo is the oldest and simplest form of melodic music, and can be the most expressive way of conveying the meaning of words. From the simplest lullaby sung to soothe a child, to a rousing football song—the solo has a unique place in music.



◁ "She Moved Through the Fair"

Notated here is a typical example of a folk song. It is sung with rhythmic freedom to ensure that the text is projected with near speechlike clarity.

Homophony

Meaning "same voices," homophony is the word for describing music that moves in block chords. Usually, the upper line has the melody, while the lower parts provide harmonic accompaniment. Homophony is most often heard in hymns and barbershop quartets.

▷ "Gaudeamus igitur," Brahms

Set homophonically, this popular song tune—"Gaudeamus igitur" ("Let us therefore rejoice")—is included in Brahms' *Academic Festival Overture*.